Fusion of functions revisited: Independent determinatives in English

Brett Reynolds *
Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

15th October 2026

Abstract

The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language (*CGEL*) analyses independent determinatives, as in *take some* and *the lucky few*, with fused functions: one word realizes Head together with Determiner or Modifier. Holding *CGEL*'s separate determinative category fixed, I argue that ordinary Head relations do better. Both analyses make the determinative the ultimate head; they differ in the relations in between. On the ordinary analysis, the determinative heads a nominal that heads the noun phrase, so *the lucky few* has the structure of *the lucky survivors*. The discriminating case is *the some who say it*. Since *the* fills Det, a fused analysis must make *some* a modifier-head, and for determinatives *CGEL* ties that to an internal-modifier use, as *the few mistakes* licenses *the few*; *some* has no such use, and corpus checks find *the some people* only as typos. Converting *some* to a noun or adding a construction-specific rule would each add a stipulation that ordinary Head avoids, and dropping the condition would reduce fusion's licence to a lexical list, the permissions ordinary Head uses anyway. Ordinary Head also lets the complex determinatives *a few* and *many a* be analysed as peripheral *a* and predeterminer *many*, as expansion (*a good few*) and agreement (*a few are*, *many a man is*) suggest. Fusion remains where it does independent work, with adjectives (*the idle rich*).

Keywords: determinatives; fused heads; headedness; noun phrase; quantifiers; English grammar

AI use. The large language models GPT-6 (Astra), Claude Fable 5.1, Claude Opus 5 and 5.5, Claude Haiku 4.5, GLM-5.3-Flash, and GPT-5.6 (Sol) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language (*CGEL*; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002) analyses *some* in *take some* as a determinative that fills two functions at once, determiner and head of the noun phrase, and *few* in *the lucky few* as filling modifier and head. Payne et al. (2007) make this fusion of functions explicit, extend it to *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, and argue that it does better than analyses

*Contact: brett.reynolds@humber.ca

with a null head. I argue that for determinatives a simpler configuration does the same work: the determinative is the ordinary Head of a nominal (Nom), and the nominal heads the NP.

Their account rests on a distinction I keep. Lexical categories such as determinative are distinct from syntactic functions such as determiner, and an NP such as *some apples* is headed by its noun. I also keep fusion where they show it doing work nothing else does: in fused relatives, where case matching follows from one constituent bearing two functions (Payne et al., 2007, pp. 576–579), and in fused-head adjectives such as *the rich*. And I take over their strongest argument, that null heads need stipulations fusion avoids (Payne et al., 2007, 570 n. 5, 584), and use it against an ellipsis analysis of the determinatives (§10).

Fusion, as they define it, departs from canonical structure in two ways. One constituent has two mothers, which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure which FF entails" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 570). And a phrase can have an ultimate head of another category, "the second departure", which "will be independently required in the case of hybrid constructions" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 571). The ordinary-Head analysis keeps the second departure, since a determinative heads the NP's Nom, and drops the first. Both analyses make *some* the ultimate head of *take some*; they differ in whether its phrase also fills the determiner function.

I hold *CGEL*'s categories fixed throughout. Determinative stays a primary category beside noun, and the analysis licenses ordinary Head for both N and D. Nothing here depends on how determinatives are classified.

The two analyses come apart in *the some who say it*. With *the* in Det, a fused analysis has to make *some* a modifier-head, and *CGEL* licenses a fused modifier-head for the determinatives that can be internal modifiers (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 415). *Some* can't: *CGEL* lists it among those that "cannot combine with the articles" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 539). A fusion grammar can list *the some who* as an exception or drop the condition, and §4 argues that dropping it leaves the shared constituent predicting nothing.

I use DETERMINATIVE for the category containing articles, demonstratives, and quantifiers such as *the*, *this*, *some*, *every*, and *many*.[1] I reserve DETERMINER for the syntactic function within the noun phrase (NP) characteristically performed by phrases headed by these words. This distinction separates what kind of word *some* is from what syntactic relationships its phrase participates in.

Lexical categories and syntactic functions cut across one another. An NP can function as determiner, as in *Kim's book*, and a determinative-headed phrase can function as modifier, as in *the many people* (Payne et al., 2010; Pullum & Miller, 2022).

Compare *take some apples* with *take some*. The word *some* remains determinative in both. Before *apples*, its phrase functions as determiner; without *apples*, the whole expression functions as object.

In these NP comparisons, DEPENDENT describes a determinative's use as determiner or internal modifier with a nominal target; INDEPENDENT describes use without that target. An independent expression can still have dependents of its own, as in *some of the wine*, and rely on context for its interpretation.

The DP hypothesis of Abney (1987) concerns a different Head relation. Under that hypothesis, D heads expressions such as *some apples*. I retain noun-headed NPs and reject the DP analysis for English, following the arguments of Pullum and Miller (2022) and Bruening (2020). Here DP means DETERMINATIVE PHRASE, as in *CGEL*.

[1] For a fuller inventory, see the online "List of determinatives in English" accompanying Huddleston et al. (2022).

Table 1 is a key to the labels used throughout, since they mark four different things: what category a word belongs to, what category its phrase belongs to, the layer inside NP, and what function a constituent fills.

Table 1: Labels used here, by what they label.

What it labels	Labels	Example
Lexical category of a word	N (noun), with a subscript for the subcategory; D (determinative)	*apples* is N_{common}; *some* is D
Phrase category	NP, DP, AdjP, AdvP, PP	*some apples* is an NP; in *CGEL* independent *some* heads a DP, and with ordinary Head an NP
The layer inside NP, excluding an external determiner	Nom	*red apples* in *some red apples*
Function of a constituent within its phrase	Det, Head, Mod, predeterminer, peripheral modifier	*some* fills Det in *some apples*
How Head is filled	ordinary Head (Head alone) against fusion (one constituent fills Head and a dependent function)	*CGEL*'s independent *some* fills Det–Head

Section 2 sets out the independent uses both analyses have to cover, and §3 compares their Head relations, ending with *the some who*. Section 4 takes the repairs open to fusion. Sections 5–7 turn to modifier attachment, the compounds (*once* among them), and genitives, and §8 applies ordinary Head to *CGEL*'s complex determinatives. Section 9 compares the analyses as fragments, and §10 answers ellipsis.

2 Independent determinatives

NPs serve as subjects, objects, and complements of prepositions; independent determinative expressions share these functions.

Independent use is widespread within the determinative inventory. *CGEL* discusses such uses for demonstratives and quantifiers including *some*, *all*, *both*, *many*, *few*, *several*, *each*, *either*, *neither*, *much*, and *enough*, while recording lexical restrictions and the separate forms *no*/*none* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 371–372, 410–424). The generalization concerns the availability of independent constructions across a lexical category, not unrestricted acceptability in every sentence frame.[2]

[2] Material before a determiner falls outside the independent-use comparison. *CGEL* treats *all*/*both* in *all/both the books* as predeterminer modifiers, *quite*/*rather* before *a good idea* as peripheral modifiers, and *such*/exclamative *what* before *a disaster* as adjectives (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 433–437); §8.2 reanalyses that pair, and the *many* of *CGEL*'s complex determinative *many a* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 394), as determinatives in predeterminer function. The *half* in *half a cake* is a common noun used as a predeterminer modifier (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 434). These constructions don't add evidence for independent determinative heads.

With Kim and a group of people under discussion, compare the bracketed NPs in (1).

(1) a. [*People*] *left.* *I see* [*people*]. *with* [*people*]
b. [*Kim*] *left.* *I see* [*Kim*]. *with* [*Kim*]
c. [*She*] *left.* *I see* [*her*]. *with* [*her*]
d. [*Some*] *left.* *I see* [*some*]. *with* [*some*]

NPs containing fused-head adjective phrases (AdjPs) fill the same positions. *The rich* and *the poor* are NP arguments, and comparative and superlative adjectives head expressions without a generic human interpretation: *CGEL*'s *the most important of her criticisms* is an NP containing a partitive *of* -phrase (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 332–333, 416–423).

Independent *some* can form a one-word NP, whereas an NP with *rich* as fused Head requires the definite article *the* on the generic human reading (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 417–418). Singular count common nouns also need determination in argument NPs.

With possible solutions under discussion, *There are several* places the independent quantifier in displaced-subject position; dummy *there* is the subject (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1391–1393).

Common nouns freely take integrated relatives, as in *people who came*; personal pronouns permit a restricted range, including *we who have read the report* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 430). Determinative examples include *few who come ever leave*, *those who came*, *that which remains*, and *something that you need to know*.

Compounds also permit *anyone who asks* and *everything that matters*. With books under discussion, compare *some that I saw* and *two that I have seen*. *CGEL* describes relative postmodification with demonstratives and compounds (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 414, 422–423).

Compound determinatives also take post-head adjectives, as in *I need something reliable and good looking*.[3] The position and interpretation of these modifiers have specialized conditions (§6).

3 Ordinary Head and fusion

This section compares ordinary Head with fusion in independent *some*, *some of the wine*, and *the lucky few*. Ordinary headedness gives the determinative Head alone; fusion combines Head with a dependent function.

3.1 The basic Head relations

A nominal (Nom) contains a head and its internal dependents, excluding an external determiner. In *some apples*, the word *apples* heads Nom, and that Nom heads NP. The same arrangement permits an internal modifier, as in *some red apples*, without making the determining phrase part of the Nom.

Head is the function of an immediate constituent within a phrase. The ultimate lexical head is the word reached by following Head relations through the intervening phrase layers. Thus *apples* is the ultimate lexical head of *some apples*, although the NP's immediate Head is Nom. Both accounts also have *some* as the ultimate lexical head of independent *some*.

[3] Attested in CGELBank; the accompanying *corpus supplement* in the evidence repository identifies the source sentence and its annotation.

A standard tree has unique parentage: each constituent below the root has one parent. Fusion allows branches to converge on a shared constituent with two parents. In the ordinary-Head analysis, the determinative's projection needs no such join. Figure 1 compares the structures.[4]

On the ordinary-Head analysis, a determinative can head this Nom–NP structure too. Figure 1 compares the accounts for *take some apples* and *take some*. The dependent expression still has *apples* as its ultimate head. Independent *some* has ordinary Head on that analysis; in *CGEL*, its DP jointly fills Det of NP and Head of Nom.

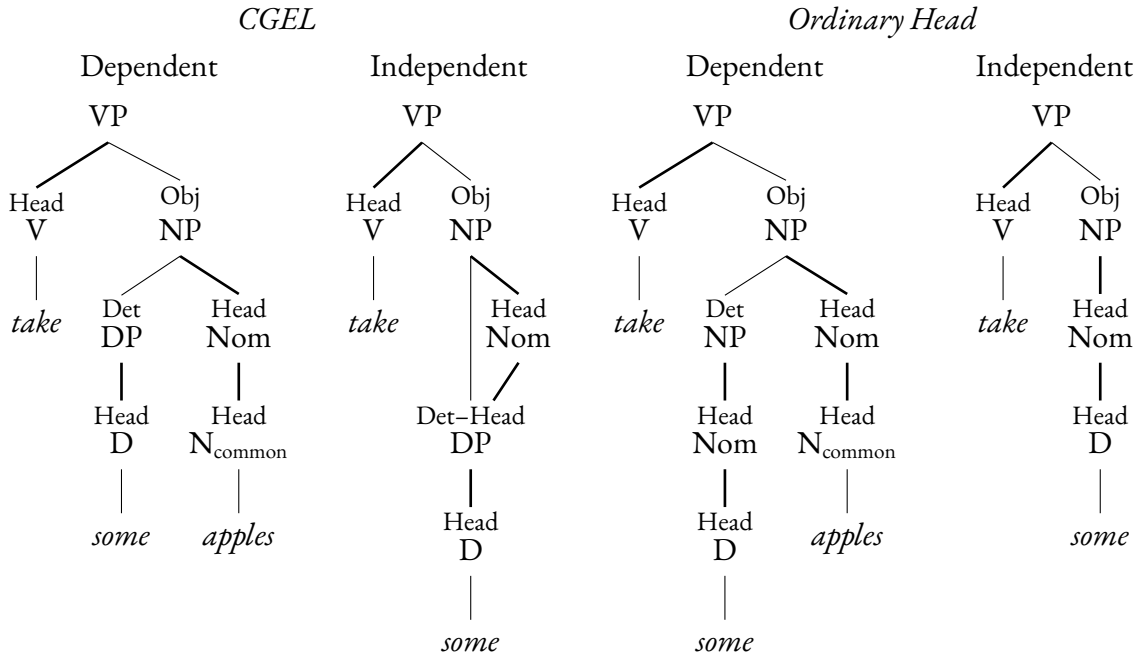


Figure 1: *Take some apples* and *take some* under *CGEL* (first pair) and the ordinary-Head analysis (second pair). Within each pair, the dependent use precedes the independent use. In the second diagram, DP fills Det of NP and Head of Nom. In the second pair, *some* has the same NP projection in Det and Obj uses. Function labels appear above category labels. Det marks determiner, Obj object, and Det–Head fusion; the two links show the combined functions. N, D, and V mark noun, determinative, and verb; NP, DP, and VP mark their phrases. Subscripts identify noun subcategories.

Ordinary headedness supplies the direct Nom–NP projection used here. With D kept separate, a grammar licenses it by admitting both N and D as the lexical Head of Nom (§9.2).

The genitive NP *Kim's* fills Det in *Kim's preferences*, whose ultimate lexical head is *preferences*. Ordinary determinative headedness gives *some* that phrase type in Det and object uses alike. Plain determinative-headed NPs, such as *almost ten* in *almost ten apples*, then join genitives such as *Kim's* and *my*. The fragment compares the remaining selectional conditions (§9.2).

[4] The proposal retains fusion elsewhere, including Mod–Head fusion in *the rich*. The preference for unique parentage concerns the determinative's Head configuration, rather than every construction in the grammar.

3.2 Syntactic completeness and contextual interpretation

With a group of people under discussion, *Some left*, *Many came*, and *All agree* illustrate syntactic completeness: an argument expression can be complete without another overt head or determiner. Bare *few* shows the same with no group under discussion: *few would dare underestimate Aaron Finch's men* and *few have had the opportunity to digest its contents*.[5] In *I'll take some*, the relevant substance or set may still be supplied by discourse or the situation. Ordinary pronouns also depend on context.

Generalizing expressions such as *Many are called, few are chosen* and *Enough is enough* need no previously uttered common-noun phrase. Interpretation can instead depend on the situation or a generic restriction. Generic pronoun *one*, as in *One shouldn't judge*, provides a parallel without a required overt antecedent.

The comparison with ordinary pronouns and proper nouns is structural as well as interpretive. In *She left* and *Kim left*, *CGEL* permits an NP headed by a nominal with no determiner. Applying that structure to *Some left* preserves the same division between a complete NP and its context-dependent reference.

Fusion represents the same complete expression differently: in Payne et al. (2007), one constituent jointly realizes Head and a dependent function, subject to structural and adjacency conditions. Both analyses keep an overt determinative and can express the restriction supplied by context; §9.4 compares them on the structures they share.

3.3 Partitives and externally determined expressions

In *some of the wine*, *some* specifies a quantity drawn from an identifiable amount of wine. The NP *the wine* denotes the partitive domain and is complement of *of*. A pronoun-headed NP or independent genitive NP can express the domain too: *many of them*, referring to previously mentioned people, or *some of Kim's*, referring to Kim's apples.

Compare where the common noun occurs in *some apples* and *some of the wine*. In the partitive, *wine* is embedded inside the *of*-phrase, so it can't be the ultimate lexical head of the whole NP. The Head relations in both analyses lead instead to *some*.

Figure 2 gives the ordinary-Head analysis, with the *of*-phrase functioning as complement within Nom, as in *CGEL*'s partitive tree (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 411–412). In *CGEL*, the phrase headed by *some*, a DP in its sense, fills Det–Head. Both analyses let the overt quantifier and domain supply a compositional interpretation. They agree on the ultimate lexical head and differ in the intervening Head relations.

[5] NOW: *Daily Times* (Pakistan), 20 October 2022; *New York Times*, 4 March 2022. Brett Reynolds read all 94 NOW lines for *few would*: 82 have nothing in the visible context that supplies the set, 3 have it and 2 probably do ("letting 1,000 flowers bloom and hoping a few would pan out", *Computerworld*, 2021), and 7 can't be decided from the window. The records and screening-model comparison are in the quantifier supplement in the evidence repository.

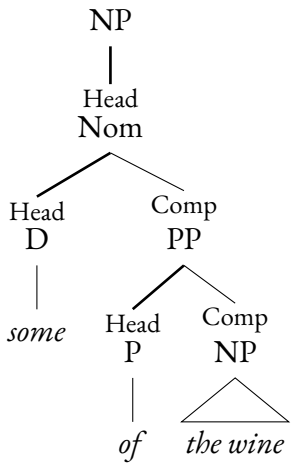


Figure 2: *Some of the wine* under the ordinary-Head analysis. The Head relations lead from the outer NP to *some*. The common noun *wine* is inside the complement PP and doesn't head the whole expression. The inner NP is abbreviated.

Independent *few* and certain other indefinite determinatives permit definite determination. On the ordinary-Head analysis, *few* heads an ordinary NP both alone and in *the few*, where *the* fills Det. Adding an optional adjective gives *the lucky few*, with the same Head and dependent functions as *the lucky survivors*.[6]

CGEL permits determinatives used as internal modifiers to fuse with Head, as in *the other two* and *these few here* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 415–416). Its analysis of *the few mistakes* assigns *the* to Det and *few* to Mod (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392). That dependent use supplies the counterpart for a Mod–Head analysis of independent *few* after an external determiner.

Figure 3 compares the resulting analyses of *the lucky few*. Both have an overt Det and a Nom modified by *lucky*. In the ordinary-Head analysis, the lexical word *few* directly heads Nom. In the fusion analysis, its DP fills Mod–Head, the machinery of adjectival fusion.

[6] *The lucky few* is attested as an independent argument with a relative: "Are you one of the lucky few who found powdered infant formula?" (*National Observer*, 3 October 2022); "is among the lucky few who already have that permanent freedom" (*Business Insider*, 11 February 2021). Both from NOW, 17 September 2026; further examples are in the quantifier supplement in the evidence repository.

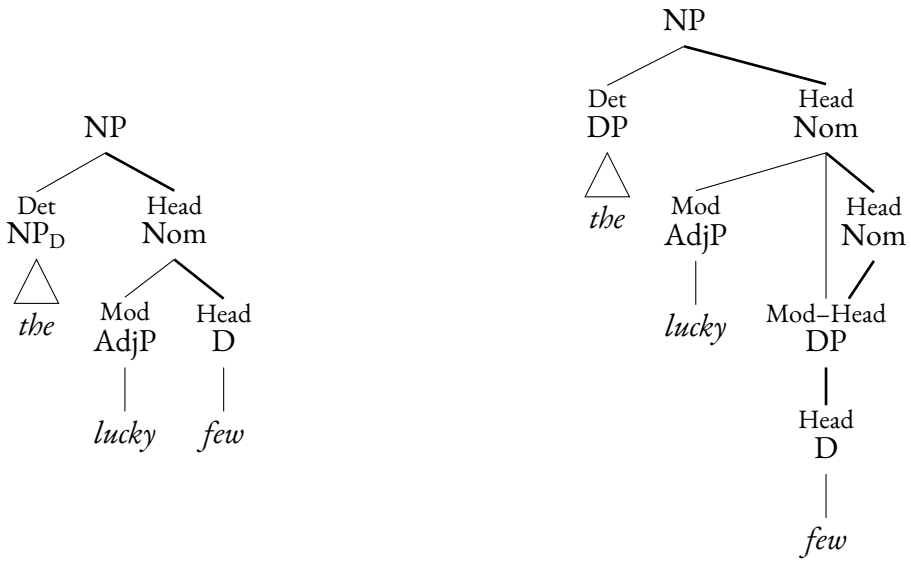


Figure 3: *The lucky few* with ordinary Head (left) and Mod–Head fusion (right). The determiner is separately realized in both. Internal structure within the article phrase and AdjP is suppressed. NP_D marks a determinative-headed NP.

Table 2 compares the Head relations across six constructions; §9.2 supplies the constraints.

Table 2: Head and dependent functions under matched analyses. Each independent expression is an NP; the phrase headed by *the* fills Det wherever it appears. Form labels abbreviate the corresponding constituents shown in the trees.

Expression	Separate D with fusion	Ordinary determinative Head
few survivors	*few*: Det; *survivors*: Head	Same functions
Independent *few*	*few*: Det–Head	*few*: Head
the few	*few*: Mod–Head	*few*: Head
the lucky few	*few*: Mod–Head; *lucky*: Mod	*few*: Head; *lucky*: Mod
the some who	*some*: Mod–Head, with no internal-modifier use	*some*: Head
the idle rich	*rich*: Mod–Head; *idle*: Mod	Same fusion and modifier functions

Fusion groups *the lucky few* with *the idle rich*; ordinary headedness groups it with *the lucky survivors* and unifies bare and externally determined *few*. The choice is between sharing fusion across D and adjective, and sharing ordinary Head structure across determinative constructions.

Reducing fusion's applications can simplify this description even when fusion remains available for adjectives and the nominal *nylon* and *double* constructions (§7). The advantage is the uniform treatment of *few*; its value depends on any additional conditions or lost generalizations elsewhere. Section 9.4 compares those costs while holding the lexical restrictions fixed.

Some separates the two analyses where *few* doesn't. In dependent use it has no internal-modifier function: *CGEL* lists it among the determinatives that "cannot combine with the articles" (Huddle-

ston & Pullum, 2002, p. 539), and there's no *the some people* to match *the few people*. Yet independent *some* takes *the*, which that criterion excludes as worded: *when times are bad, the some will become the many*; *Perhaps the author is one of the some who hope for a return to the good old days*.[7] Since *the* fills Det, a fused analysis must make *some* a modifier-head, and for determinatives *CGEL* ties the fused modifier-head to an internal-modifier use (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410, 415), which *some* lacks. That's the anomaly *CGEL* records for *the both of us*, where *both* "cannot occur in internal modifier function" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 377).

That condition predicts that *the some* is rare, as it is, but not that it occurs. With *some* as an ordinary Head and *the* in Det, nothing needs licensing, and the rarity has a semantic source. *Some* is existential (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 380), so once *the* identifies the set, *some* adds only that the set is part of a larger one. That's worth saying when the larger set is in view: against *the many*, after a partitive (*one of the some who*), or taking up an earlier indefinite (*our country needs some of us to sacrifice, the some of us who can*).

The remaining three extends the modifier pattern to cardinals. It doesn't independently decide whether *three* is determinative or has a common-noun use: Reynolds (2026) argues for both uses of cardinals.

4 Repairs to fusion

A fusion analysis can admit *the some who* in four ways: list it as an exception, convert *some* to a noun, add a rule for the construction, or weaken the condition that ties a fused modifier-head to an internal-modifier use. The first three each add a statement. The fourth removes the part of fusion that predicts which determinatives take *the*.

That condition is where fusion's predictions come from. *CGEL* states it generally, "the expression in fused-head position can occur in the dependent position in NPs where it is not fused with the head" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 410), and lists among "the cases where fusion is possible" the determinatives "which can function as internal modifier as well as determiner" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 415). Payne et al. (2007, p. 571) list the correspondence among fusion's properties: the fused constituent has the dependent's category in any counterpart construction.

On that condition a determinative takes *the* without a following noun just when it takes *the* with one. *Few*, *many*, and the cardinals do both (*the few mistakes*, *the few*); *any*, *each*, and *every* do neither. *Some* does the second without the first, and so does *both* in *the both of us*.

[7] COCA, 15 October 2026: one display page of `the some` (197 lines) has *when times are bad, the some will become the many* (*Foreign Affairs*, 1999) and *benefit the all rather than the some* (yilb.com, 2012), and expanded context adds *drove the some into Louisiana, Arkansas and Oklahoma* after a run of *many* (juneteenth.com, 2012); `the some who` and `the some of us who` add *the some who say it is the General Accounting Office* (*ABC Nightline*, 1990) and the *some of us* line (*CBS Sunday Morning*, 2010). The page's other hits are typos for *same*, approximate numbers with the adverb *some* "approximately" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 385), disfluent or non-native *the some of the*, titles, and spam; five *the some* + noun lines can be read as a contrast (*even though the some users might benefit more then others*, zerohedge.com) or as a stray *the*, which the iWeb comparison below tests. iWeb has 10 hits for `the some who`, among them the *good old days* line (sspnet.org) and *one of the some who are required to have the crusading attitude* (netk.net.au); most have no earlier *some* in view, so they aren't quotations of the word. Of its 53 hits for `the some people`, the 50 displayed have none in such a frame: *the* stands for *that* in 15 (*the fact the some people don't care*), for *same* in 2, and comes before plain indefinite *some people* in 24 (closest to a contrast: *the some people can't hope to play while others seem unaffected*); the rest are titles or garbled text. The lines were classified by Claude Opus 5.5, and the readings are saved with them under `corpus/exclusion_tests/` in the evidence repository.

Listing exceptions is the route *CGEL* takes for *the both of us*, where *both* "cannot occur in internal modifier function" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 377). It suits that case, because *the both of* is a fixed frame: in COCA, 1,424 of its 1,437 tokens have a personal pronoun after *of*, as *CGEL* says they should.[8] *The some* has no single frame. It occurs with a relative (*the some who say it*), with a partitive and a relative (*the some of us who can*), and in contrasts (*the some will become the many*; §3.3). An exception for *some* has to cover all three, which makes it a lexical entry, not a listed construction.

The obvious weakening licenses a fused modifier-head for any determinative with an independent use. It overgenerates: *any* and *each* have independent uses (*can't find any*, *each of them*), but neither takes *the*, and none of the 94 COCA lines for *the any* has the determinative. So a weakened condition has to be a list of the determinatives that take *the*.

Payne et al. (2007, p. 570) allow for this: fusion constructions and their counterparts "frequently differ in other respects ... and in some cases no counterpart even exists". Their one case without a counterpart, though, is the fused relative headed by a PP, AdjP, or AdvP, as in *in whichever city they want me to work* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 575). Every determinative they analyse has a counterpart: *this once* has *this one time* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 588). Their "lexical distinction between determinatives that allow FF and those that do not" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 581) restricts fusion where a counterpart exists, as with **every of the students*; it doesn't license fusion where none exists.

Extending the exemption to determinatives turns the licence into a list: *few*, *many*, the cardinals, and *some* may follow *the*, and *any*, *each*, and *every* may not. Ordinary Head needs the same list, as permissions for external determination. A default, with *some* and *both* as exceptions, is open to ordinary Head as well: a determinative that follows *the* as a modifier usually follows it as a head. Stating that default doesn't need a shared constituent, which Payne et al. call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure which FF entails" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 570).

Conversion avoids the licence altogether. *CGEL* uses it for *a nobody* and *a little something* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 423 n. 43). Determinatives do convert, and the conversions have recognizable marks. An *America* article coins *nones and somes* for the religiously unaffiliated and affiliated, with plural inflection and adjectives (*Catholic or Protestant somes*). COCA also has *any* as a category label (*the any symptom operational definition*), *enough* as an abstract noun (*it is the enough that defines me*), and *all* for a whole person (*the whole me, the all of me*).[9]

These conversions name a category or a property; none quantifies over a set already in view. *The some who* does: in *one of the some who hope for a return to the good old days*, *the some* picks out part of a larger group. A noun can quantify, as *lot* and *number* do (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 349–350), so conversion isn't excluded outright. But the converted noun would need exactly the properties of independent *some*, its partitive (*the some of us who*) and its quantity reading, and none of

[8] COCA, 15 October 2026, searches run by hand: `the both of *` returns 1,437 tokens, 1,394 before *you*, *us*, or *them* and 30 before dialect or clitic forms of personal pronouns (*youse*, *y'all*, *'em*); the other 13 weren't screened. The same session checked the other determinatives without an internal-modifier use. `the much that` returns one line, a literary parallel to *the little* ("The little that is said is eked out by implication of the much that was done", blog, 2012); plain *much* is "largely restricted to non-affirmative contexts" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 393), so its absence says nothing about fusion. Of 98 lines for `the all of`, 13 use *all* as a noun for a whole (*no one is seeing the all of me*) and 3, from two writers, quantify (*Can you fix the all of me that's broken?*). Of 94 lines for `the any` and 35 for `the enough`, none has the determinative after *the*. The lines were classified by Claude Opus 5.5 and are saved under `corpus/exclusion_tests/` in the evidence repository.

[9] COCA, 15 October 2026: *America* (2015); a text labelled *LearningDisability* (academic, 2014); *Big Stone Gap* (fiction, 2000); a text labelled *Iris* (fiction, 2004). Screens under `corpus/exclusion_tests/` in the evidence repository.

the properties the attested conversions show. That's a duplicate of the determinative under another category.

A rule for the construction could license *the* with *some* where the larger set is in view: against *the many*, after a partitive, or after an earlier indefinite. That condition is the semantic account of the construction's rarity in §3.3, which ordinary Head needs anyway. Under fusion the rule states it again, for a fused modifier-head that the general licence excludes.

5 Modifier selection and attachment

Degree *very*, *so*, and *too* select gradable heads: *very tall* and *very few*, but **so you*, **so the book*, and **too my life*. These degree modifiers also exclude non-gradable determinatives: **very every*, **very some*, and **very this*. The associated series includes *so few*, *too few*, *how few*, and *as few as*. These degree patterns select *few*, *many*, *much*, and *little*, the four determinatives that inflect for grade (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 393–395, 431–432).[10]

Approximative and focusing modifiers have a broader distribution. Compare *almost every*, *nearly all*, *hardly any*, *practically no*, *almost everyone*, and *almost ten*. They have counterparts in established NP modification: *almost the whole class*, *hardly a day*, and *only the best*. In *almost every student*, *almost* approximates the quantity; it doesn't intensify a gradable property of *every*.

This selection contrast guides the attachment analysis. Approximative and focusing modifiers have established NP parallels; the degree series selects the four gradable quantifiers. Ordinary Head can represent that difference by distinguishing NP-peripheral modification from modification inside Nom.

Peripheral modifiers attach outside an NP's internal dependents. Compare *only you*, *for almost my entire life*, and *Usually a careful driver, Anne found her mind wandering*. The modifiers precede any determiner belonging to the NP they modify. *CGEL* assigns them NP-level attachment (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 430–431). Focusing *even* and *just*, and approximatives such as *nearly*, *hardly*, *virtually*, and *practically*, likewise have NP uses.

In *almost every experienced teacher*, *almost* belongs with *every*, while *experienced* modifies *teacher*. Figure 4 places *almost* at the periphery of the NP headed by *every*. That smaller NP functions as Det in the larger NP, whose ultimate head is *teacher*.

[10] The restriction concerns this degree series. *CGEL* also records modifiers of completeness, including *marginally enough* and *absolutely all*, with different selectional ranges (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 432). Those combinations don't extend the *very*/*so*/*too*/*how* series beyond the four degree determinatives.

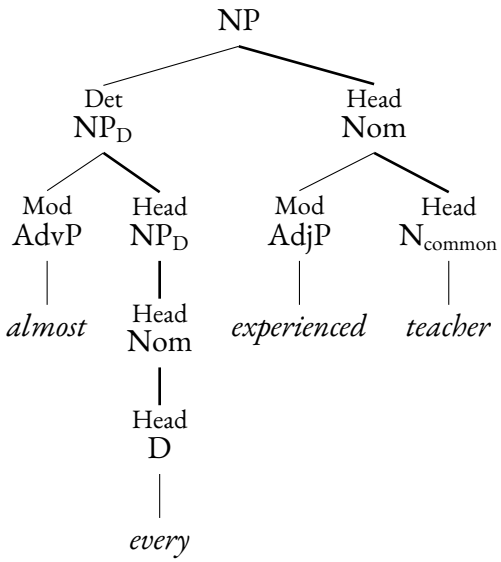


Figure 4: Peripheral *almost* modifies the smaller NP headed by *every*; the resulting *almost every* NP functions as Det. The adjective *experienced* modifies the common-noun nominal. Internal structure within the one-word modifier phrases is suppressed.

Payne et al. (2010, pp. 40–42) defend keeping *few*, *any*, and related forms in one lexical category across dependent and independent uses. In *hardly any money* and independent *hardly any*, *hardly* remains an adverb and *any* retains its category. The D-noun analysis preserves that continuity. It also preserves their contrast between adverbial premodification, as in *almost anybody*, and adjectival postmodification, as in *nothing absolute* (Payne et al., 2010, pp. 41–42).

The proposed analysis gives adverbs such as *very* and *too* internal attachment in dependent and independent uses alike. In *the very few people*, *very* modifies the Nom headed by *few*; the resulting *very few* NP functions as Mod in the larger NP. In *the very few who objected*, *few* remains ordinary Head and *very* remains internal. The degree relation is unchanged, and one internal condition covers both constructions. The same analysis applies to *the very many*.

NP degree modifiers provide a further connection. Determinatives permit determinative premodifiers such as *this* in *this much* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 393). Comparative determinatives also take established NP modifiers: *a lot* in *a lot fewer*, alongside *CGEL*'s *a lot more than fifty* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 432). These modify the quantity expressed by the head. Under the proposed analysis, they're internal NP modifiers within its NP projection.

Approximatives also need internal attachment where they follow an external determiner on an independent cardinal: *the almost thirty who came*. The internal AdvP conditions at issue are thus the degree series on *few*, *many*, *much*, and *little* across dependent and independent uses, and approximatives on externally determined independent cardinals.

6 Compounds and their modifier domains

A more demanding modifier comparison is *hardly anyone present*. Payne et al. (2007, pp. 581–583) assign *hardly* to DP structure and *present* to structure within the nominal. The compound *anyone*

takes the premodifiers of its determinative base *any*: compare *hardly any writer present*. The adjective realizes a specialized RESTRICTOR function, restricted to post-head position and non-recursive. Figure 5 contrasts this account with an ordinary-Head analysis.

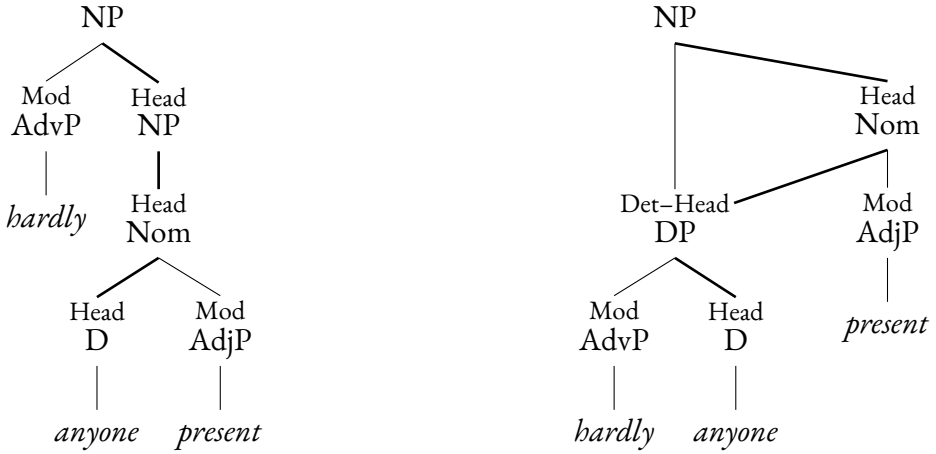


Figure 5: *Hardly anyone present* with ordinary Head (left) and fusion (right). On the left, *hardly* is peripheral to NP and *present* is internal to Nom. Both post-head Mod positions realize the specialized restrictor. In the fusion tree, DP fills Det of NP and Head of Nom, following Payne et al. (2007, p. 582, (13d)). Modifier-phrase interiors are suppressed.

In the ordinary-Head tree, *anyone* heads Nom and NP and takes its premodifier conditions from its determinative base. Peripheral *hardly* follows the approximative pattern and its NP parallels in §5. The compound construction supplies the post-head restrictor, with the same position and non-recursion conditions as the fusion account, and in its primary use it excludes external determination.

The relative clauses in §2 are ordinary postmodifiers, distinct from the specialized restrictor. When both occur, the relative follows it: *something useful that I found*. *CGEL* gives compounds the common noun's range of ordinary postmodifiers, subject to this ordering condition (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 423).

The same division applies to *someone* and *everybody*: the compound construction licenses the post-head restrictor, while the determinative base supplies its premodifier conditions. The example *something reliable and good looking* illustrates the post-head pattern (§2).

Both accounts separate the modifier domains structurally: fusion uses the DP–Nom boundary, and ordinary headedness uses the NP–Nom boundary. As drawn in Figure 5, ordinary Head groups *anyone present* in the inner NP, whereas fusion groups *hardly anyone* in DP. That difference doesn't give a constituency test, though. *CGEL*'s peripheral modifiers include scaling modifiers of whole NPs, as in *After [hardly a moment's hesitation] he agreed* and *he was doing [exactly that]* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 437), where independent *that* heads a fused-head NP (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 422). A fusion grammar can parse *[hardly [anyone present]]* the same way.

The same inventory bears on what Payne et al. (2007, p. 583) count as "a particular strength of the FF analysis", its explanation of why compounds take adverbs as premodifiers and adjectives as postmodifiers. On the ordinary-Head analysis the adverbs are the NP-peripheral modifiers *CGEL* already lists, and the adjectives are restrictors inside Nom. The premodifiers don't favour either account.

Fusion does explain one fact that ordinary Head has to state. A bare compound takes no pre-head adjective (**nice anyone*). With *anyone* in fused Det–Head, an adjective would have to precede the determiner, and Payne et al. (2007, p. 584) derive the exclusion from adjacency and the ban on crossing branches, where a null-headed analysis needs a stipulation. Ordinary Head states it as a condition: a compound determinative takes a pre-head adjective only under external determination. The condition also gives *this last once* against **last once* (§6.1). It's one statement in each account, but fusion's follows from a general principle and this one doesn't.

6.1 *Once*, *twice*, and *thrice*

Payne et al. (2007) develop fusion through *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, which they analyse as compound determinatives, "analogous in many respects to expressions like *someone* and *somewhere*" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 565). Numerical *once* is fused Det–Head when bare, as in *Once is enough*, and fused Mod–Head after a determiner, as in *only the once* and *this last once*, on the model of *one time* and *this one time* (Payne et al., 2007, pp. 586, 588).

On the ordinary-Head analysis *once* heads Nom and NP, as *anyone* does. With a determiner it patterns with the cardinals, whose independent NPs take external determination: *instead of the once that we're doing now* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 586) beside *the two that I have seen*. Its pre-head modifiers come from its base, as for *one*: *at least once* and *more than once* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 589). The condition on pre-head adjectives gives *this last once*, and the restrictor slot admits *more*, as in *once more* beside *something more* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 591).

None of this calls for a fusion licence beyond the one *once* already satisfies: its base *one* has a modifier use (*this one time*), so *this once* and *every once in a while* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 587) fall under the counterpart condition of §4. They don't distinguish the analyses, and they don't need the shared constituent either.

7 Independent genitives and retained fusion

CGEL also uses fusion with nouns. Anaphoric *mine*, understood as 'my car', combines the possessive relation with an understood nominal description and receives a fused analysis. Predicative *mine*, as in *it's mine*, can instead mean 'belongs to me': it expresses the relation directly, without an understood nominal head (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410–411, 469–471). A suitable context may permit either reading.

The proposed analysis gives *mine* ordinary Head in both anaphoric and predicative uses. Its genitive form expresses a relation to the speaker; context can supply the understood nominal description, as it can with independent *few*. The *my*/*mine* alternation remains a form-selection condition, parallel to *no*/*none*. This extends ordinary headedness to an existing noun subcategory.

The genitive's person identifies the possessor; the independent NP's agreement follows the possessed entity or entities. Compare *Mine is ready* ('my contribution') and *Mine are ready* ('my slides'). Ordinary Head needs a constructional agreement condition.

Anaphoric genitives also need a condition on complements. *CGEL* contrasts the following NPs (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 420–421, (36ii), (37iib)):

(2) a. *Alice's performance of the Schubert and* [*Helen's of the Rachmaninov*]
b. **Alice's attempt to play the Schubert and* [*Helen's the Rachmaninov*]

In the first, *Helen's* is understood as Helen's performance, and the following *of*-PP has the complement relation licensed by *performance*. The second can't omit *attempt to play* and keep the bare object of *play*. The grammatical NP also occurs outside coordination, after *immediately after*, where clausal gapping is excluded (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 420–421, (37i)).

I allow the anaphoric genitive construction to recover the antecedent's nominal description and its complement frame, without inheriting complements of verbs embedded within it. The recovered frame supplements the overt head's dependent permissions. This condition, like the agreement condition, is an additional commitment of the ordinary-Head extension to genitives. Functional fusion marks the recovered dependent relation, but also requires an account of which complements that relation licenses.

CGEL also considers ordinary Head for independent *many*, with no change of category, but rejects this as a general replacement for fusion (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 421). Its counterexamples are *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] and *I earn three times the amount Bill does, and Mary earns* [*double*]. Both words are nouns in its account, but *nylon* is understood as a modifier of *shirts*, and *double* as a predeterminer multiplier.

I retain fusion for those constructions. The proposal concerns the determinative constructions compared here, with a further extension to independent genitives. Its advantage comes from their shared structure; nounhood alone doesn't establish ordinary Head in every construction.

Ordinary Head gives the independent determinatives one Head chain, and their modifier conditions stay distinct. Section 9 compares the costs.

Simple forms such as **many's* and **some's* resist genitive marking. *CGEL* suggests that fusion supplies a reason: the form has to meet the case requirements of both Det and Head (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 420). Its analogy with case matching in fused relatives (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1073–1074) motivates that suggestion, but the restriction still depends on the case conditions assigned to the determinative use. Genitive NPs themselves freely fill Det.

The ordinary-Head account states the restriction lexically, and the fusion account needs a lexical statement too. *CGEL* analyses the compounds as fused determiner-heads (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 423), yet lists *everyone's* and *somebody's* among genitives (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 479). If a fused form's case had to match both its functions, *everyone's* would be excluded with *many's*. The explanation covers the simple forms only, so their exclusion has to be stated for them, as it is under ordinary Head. A lexical gap in the genitive is ordinary anyway: reflexive pronouns have none (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 426).

8 Complex determinatives

With *a few*, modifier position distinguishes two attachment sites. *CGEL* contrasts internal *very* in *a very few mistakes* with peripheral *quite* in *quite a few mistakes* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392, (61)); the reversed orders **very a few* and **a quite few* are excluded. On the analysis of §8.1, *few* heads the phrase in Det and *very* is an internal modifier within it. On that analysis both *a* and *quite* are peripheral modifiers of the larger NP, with *quite* preceding *a*.

I analyse *a* as also having a restricted peripheral modifier use. In *a few mistakes*, on that analysis, *few* heads the NP in Det, while *a* modifies the larger NP headed by *mistakes*. In independent *a few*, *a* modifies the NP headed by *few*. The singular-count target restriction belongs to *a*'s Det use; its

peripheral use selects a quantificational construction. Section 8.1 develops this analysis, and §8.2 contrasts it with predeterminer modification in *many a*.

8.1 Peripheral modification

CGEL treats *a few*, *a little*, *a great many*, and *many a* as complex determinatives, single determinatives spelled as more than one word. I argue that none of them needs that status, and that two mechanisms *CGEL* already has cover the data: peripheral modification, which takes *a few* and its congeners here, and predeterminer modification, which takes *many a* in §8.2, together with *such a* and *what a*.

CGEL's own record of *a few* tells against the treatment: it "admits *very*, *good*, and *fair*", and its internal structure is "sui generis" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 392, 394). Its case against a complex quantifier *a number of* appeals to the potential for replacement and expansion (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 351–352). Expansion is available here too: *a good few*, *a fair few*, and *a select few* beside *a very few*.[11]

I give *a little* and *a great many* the same peripheral *a*. Before another nominal, *little* and *many* head the determining phrases; independently, they head the NPs that *a* modifies. The modifier in *a great many* is obligatory (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 394). Definite *the few mistakes* retains Det *the* and internal modifier *few* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392). The functions differ from those in *a few mistakes*.

Independent *a few* takes plural agreement (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392). That follows from plural *few*; peripheral *a* contributes no singular-count requirement. Its distribution remains restricted: *several* can be a modifier after a definite determiner (*its several advantages*) (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392) but excludes peripheral *a*. The permitted internal modifiers likewise depend on the quantifier and the construction.

CGEL records that *quite*, *not*, and *only* combine readily with *a few*, in contrast to *several* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392). I retain those combinations as conditions on peripheral modification, including the order *quite a few*. The lower bound of three for *a few* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392) remains a convention of the combination; *CGEL* itself declines to let semantic motivation alone establish a complex unit (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 621).

One objection to the decomposition is semantic. The combination has its own polarity: bare *few* and *little* are negative, whereas *a few* and *a little* are positive (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 393–394). I take peripheral *a* to license a positive quantificational interpretation in these constructions. Polarity depends on the combination, not simply on the position occupied by *few* or *little*. This interpretation remains a convention of the construction under the proposed syntactic decomposition.

Conventional polarity behaviour doesn't force lexical unity: the syntactically decomposable NP *a bit* has a minimizer interpretation in *They didn't enjoy it a bit* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 549–550, 725). Here *a bit* is licensed by negation rather than itself negative (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 822–823); the parallel with *a few* is that a conventional interpretation can belong to a phrase with internal syntactic structure.

8.2 Predeterminer modification

In *many a man*, *a* fills Det and *many* is a predeterminer modifier. *Such* and exclamative *what* enter the same predeterminer analysis from the adjective side. *CGEL* classes both as adjectives, exclamative

[11] *A good few* and *a fair few* are *CGEL*'s (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 392). NOW: "I shouldn't have to leave for a select few who are uncomfortable" (*New York Daily News*, 2022); "for those select few who know" (*Electrek*, 2021).

what because it "fails all of the determinative criteria (a)–(c)": it combines with *a*, licenses no count singular head without it, and has no partitive use (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 539–540). The first two criteria test Det function, and in *such a mess* and *what a mess* the words aren't in Det.

CGEL's inventory of predeterminer modifiers includes *all*, *both*, fractions, multipliers, "a small range of adjectives (e.g. *such* in [ic])", and AdjPs such as *how large a piece*, and "a predeterminer modifier normally precedes a determiner" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 331). In *CGEL* itself, then, *such a mess* has *a* in Det and *such* as predeterminer modifier, and only the category of *such* is at issue.

The same structure covers *what a mess* and *many a man*, whose *many a CGEL* treats as a "syntactically inert" complex determinative (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 394). On this account each inertness fact follows from the function. Nothing intervenes between the word and *a* (**what long a speech*) because a predeterminer sits against the determiner of its NP, as in *all the books* and *half a cake*, and the count singular head and singular agreement of *many a man has* come from *a* and *man*.

Neither *many a* nor *what a* has an independent use, which on this account follows from predeterminer *many* and *what* requiring a following *a*-NP. With peripheral *a*, *few* and *many* retain their independent uses as well as their Det uses before another nominal (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 392, 394). That *few* can't replace *many* (**few a man*) is lexical, as admission to predeterminer function is anyway (**most the books*).

So *many a* stands to *many* as *such a* to *such* and *what a* to *what*. Each word has Det function with plural or non-count heads (*many men*, *such promise*, *what fools*) and predeterminer function with an indefinite-article NP, where the modifier is an NP, as *CGEL*'s fractions are (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 385 n. 25), or an AdjP (*how large a piece*). Neither degree *such* nor exclamative *what* has grade or degree modification (**sucher*, **a very such mess*), and exclamative *what* has no predicative use: it "occurs only as modifier in NP structure" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 920). *CGEL* classes it as an adjective (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 540), though it lacks the predicative function of central adjectives (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 528).

Van Eynde (2007, §5) draws the same line from the other side: *such a* and *what a* aren't instances of the Big Mess construction (*how long a bridge*), since *what* and *such* "are invariably lexical" and "lexically select a nominal which is either unmarked or introduced by the indefinite article".

I treat exclamative *what* and both degree and kind *such* as determinatives in the NP constructions discussed here. The two readings of *such* share *such a person* and *such people*; kind *such* also functions as an internal modifier in *many such problems*, as determinatives such as *few* and cardinals can. *CGEL* treats both ordinary readings as adjectives, reserving determinative status for legal-register uses with a bare count singular (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 435 and n. 52). Their reclassification here preserves the distinctions among Det, predeterminer, and internal modifier functions.

This extension concerns the NP uses just compared; I leave the categorization of predicative *such* and *such … that* constructions open.

With peripheral *a* in *a few* and predeterminer *many* in *many a*, none of the four remains a complex determinative in this account. Of *CGEL*'s other candidates, cardinals above a hundred are the subject of Reynolds (2026), and I leave aside *a certain*, which it adds tentatively (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 393).

9 The matched fragment and comparative costs

A grammatical FRAGMENT states conditions on a specified range of constructions. Each account assigns categories and Head relations to the same expressions. The conditions specify permitted functions, dependents, and combinations of forms. They describe structures directly, following the constraint-based approach outlined by Pullum (2020). Comparing their content and reuse makes the accounts' commitments explicit.

Table 3 sets out the two analyses with *CGEL*'s categories and the lexical restrictions held fixed.

Table 3: Fusion and ordinary Head compared, with D a separate category in both. The lexical and constructional restrictions are the same in both columns.

	Fusion (*CGEL*)	Ordinary Head
Independent determinatives	DP fills Det–Head, or Mod–Head inside an additional Nom	D heads Nom, and Nom heads NP, in bare, partitive, and externally determined uses
Category of a determinative's phrase	DP	NP
Modifier domains	DP–Nom boundary	NP–Nom boundary
External determination	Licensed by an internal-modifier use; *the both of us* and *the some who* are exceptions	A lexical permission
Constituents with two mothers	In every independent use	None for determinatives
Fusion retained	Adjectives (*the rich*), *nylon*, *double*, fused relatives	The same

9.1 Scope and use permissions

The fragment covers determination, internal nominal modification, ordinary subject, object, and complement-of-preposition uses, partitives, and the compound comparisons in §3. It admits relative postmodifiers without analysing their internal grammar. Predication, interrogative clause structure, and modification outside NP structure lie beyond its scope. Degree uses enter the wider comparison in §9.3.

Table 4 separates uses before another nominal from independent argument uses. These are lexical USE PERMISSIONS, with separate conditions selecting the appropriate form. A permission applies to an occurrence in the specified construction. Intermediate Head relations within its projection don't require a further argument permission.

Table 4: Selected permissions and form restrictions in the fragment. Det and Mod concern uses before another nominal; Mod is internal. A dash marks absence of the stated permission.

Form	Det	Mod	Subj	Obj / CompP	Target before another nominal
the	yes	–	–	–	No count or number restriction
a	yes	–	–	–	Singular count
every	yes	yes	–[a]	–[a]	Singular count; Mod after genitive Det
some	yes	–	yes	yes	Plural count or non-count
few	yes	yes	yes	yes	Plural count
no	yes	–	–	–	No count or number restriction
none	–	–	yes	yes	Not applicable
my	yes	–	–	–	No count or number restriction
mine	–	–	yes	yes	Not applicable
she	–	–	yes	–	Not applicable
her (plain)	–	–	–	yes	Not applicable

[a]The dashes for *every* represent its ordinary dependent pattern in this fragment. They don't exclude its rare anaphoric uses in published prose, such as *Every has a story* (*Patch*, 30 July 2025).

Subj and Obj denote subject and object; CompP denotes complement of a preposition. The table's Mod column concerns internal modification. Peripheral *a*, licensed with *few*, *little*, and modified *many*, has a separate modifier permission (§8.1); the singular-count target shown applies only to its Det use. The *no*/*none* and *my*/*mine* pairs distinguish forms within a paradigm (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 389–390, 470–471). Plain *she*/*her* distinguishes subject from object and prepositional-complement uses. Quotation, metalinguistic naming, and subordinate-clause uses of dependent genitives fall outside the fragment. The permissions shown for *every* describe its ordinary dependent pattern; its rare anaphoric uses fall outside this fragment.

The table's *some* is the unstressed word, whose target is plural count or non-count. The vague count singular use, *CGEL*'s *Some idiot must have left the oven on!*, where *some* competes with *a* and conveys that the identity doesn't matter (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 380), is a separate use with its own target condition, and the fragment doesn't cover it. Target restrictions apply to the nominal being determined or modified, including a nominal headed by an independent determinative. Thus *the* permits plural *few* in *the few*. Determinative-headed phrases also bear number and count properties: *few* is plural count, while *some* takes its interpretation from the construction and domain. The modifier *this* in *this much* expresses degree; its permission doesn't follow from demonstrative Det selection.

In the external uses listed above, an expression has to pass three checks: permission for its use, selection of its form, and satisfaction of target and dependent conditions. An occurrence is admissible in an external function just when all three checks succeed. Permissions are indexed to the lexeme of the phrase's lexical head. The form and condition checks may consult the surrounding structure, including the target: independent *none* is selected in *none of the students*, and *apples* is the target for *some*'s phrase in *some apples*.

Hudson (2004, pp. 7–8) distinguishes dependency from external headedness. He argues that determiner and common noun depend on each other, although only one connects the phrase to

its surroundings. The temporal-adjunct evidence he takes from Van Langendonck (1994) supports common-noun headedness: *I saw him that day* is possible, whereas **I saw him that point in time* isn't, despite the similar temporal meanings (Hudson, 2004, pp. 10–12). The lexical noun matters, as well as the determiner restrictions.

Reciprocal selection is compatible with this headedness. A singular count noun normally requires determination, while *every* normally requires another nominal and *some* doesn't. The noun can remain Head while both constituents impose conditions.

9.2 Phrase categories and structural constraints

In *some apples* and *Kim's apples*, the determining phrases share the NP category under ordinary Head. *CGEL* instead distinguishes DP from genitive NP. It also admits restricted plain-case NPs and PPs as determiners, as in *what size hat* and *over thirty ties* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, Ch. 5, §4).

I carry this PP-determiner provision over to the ordinary-Head analysis.

$$\begin{aligned} \textit{CGEL}\text{:} \quad & \text{Det} : \{\text{DP}, \text{NP}, \text{PP}\} \\ \text{Ordinary Head:} \quad & \text{Det} : \{\text{NP}, \text{PP}\} \end{aligned}$$

NP projection consolidates the principal phrase types in Det function; determinative-headed, genitive, and other licensed NPs are identified separately, and both implementations have at most one Det per NP with the same definiteness and target-selection conditions. In the separate-D ordinary-Head account, an NP's ultimate lexical head can be N or D.

The ordinary-Head account has three structural conditions. First, an NP core has a Nom, the layer inside NP, as Head and at most one Det, the determiner function. Second, a nominal core has a lexical Head and only the dependents permitted for that head in its construction. Third, peripheral modification forms an NP with the modifier as dependent and another NP as Head, as in Figure 4. This keeps peripheral modification outside the core's Det and Nom dependents.

Where a word occurrence h directly fills Head in Nom, let $\text{Cat}(h)$ record its lexical category. Fusion keeps that position for nouns and lets a DP fill Head of Nom in its fused configurations; ordinary Head adds D to the condition instead:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Fusion:} \quad & \text{Cat}(h) = \text{N} \\ \text{Ordinary Head:} \quad & \text{Cat}(h) \in \{\text{N}, \text{D}\}. \end{aligned}$$

The disjunct is what keeping D separate costs ordinary Head, and it replaces the fused configurations for determinatives. Fusion is held fixed for adjectives and the nominal *nylon* and *double* constructions of §7 in both analyses. Both permit the same Nom layers, selected complements, and ordered modifiers. For anaphoric genitives, the construction also permits complements licensed by the recovered nominal description (§7); the overt lexical head's permissions alone don't license them.

The dependent conditions distinguish uses before another nominal from independent uses. In Det or internal Mod function before a target, ordinary *some* and *few* exclude external determination, partitive complements, and relative postmodifiers within their own phrase. Independent *some* and *few* permit selected partitives and relatives; independent *few* also permits definite determination and adjectival premodification, as in *the lucky few*. These dependent conditions don't transfer to *every* or the articles.

Degree-modifier selection applies across the relevant dependent and independent uses. It includes AdvPs such as *very*, determinative-headed modifiers such as *this* in *this much*, and established NPs such as *a lot* in *a lot fewer*. Comparative complements, as in *more than ten*, are licensed separately from partitive *of*-phrases. Neither the category NP nor a general modifier slot licenses arbitrary adjectives or unrestricted complements.

Postmodification permits zero or more ordered dependents, subject to the construction. The compounds permit at most one specialized post-head restrictor followed by ordinary postmodifiers: *useful* precedes *that I found* in *something useful that I found*. In their primary use they exclude external determination and a corresponding pre-head adjective; a set-denoting use such as *a special someone* falls outside the construction. Their determinative bases supply the premodifier conditions (§6).

The approximatives retain the two attachment sites motivated in §5: peripheral NP attachment in *almost every* and internal attachment in externally determined *the almost thirty who came*. The ordinary-Head account requires this distinction.

The fragment incorporates the peripheral-*a* conditions for *a few*, *a little*, and *a great many*, including the obligatory modifier, and predeterminer *many* in *many a*, which requires a following *a*-NP (§8.2).

Each phrase's use permission follows its own lexical head. In *the apple*, the smaller article phrase has Det permission; the outer NP has argument permission through *apple*, whose determination requirement is satisfied. Bare **Book arrived* fails that requirement, while *Books arrived* passes. The article itself lacks argument permission (Table 4).

The fusion account retains these use, form, selection, and ordering conditions but assigns different Head relations. Let p be the independent NP, m its Head Nom, and x the shared determinative phrase. Let n be the additional Nom in the Mod–Head configuration. Write $\mathrm{Head}(p, m)$ for 'm fills Head in p', and likewise for Det and Mod. The two configurations satisfy the following relations:

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{Det–Head:} && \mathrm{Head}(p,m), && \mathrm{Det}(p,x), && \mathrm{Head}(m,x); \\ &\text{Mod–Head:} && \mathrm{Head}(p,m), && \mathrm{Mod}(m,x), \\ & && \mathrm{Head}(m,n), && \mathrm{Head}(n,x). \end{aligned}$$

Det–Head fills the NP's Det function, excluding a second Det. Mod–Head leaves that function available for an external determiner. Its additional Nom n matches Figure 3: the determinative phrase fills Mod in m and Head in n. The ordinary adjective *lucky* separately modifies m. These are simultaneous relations on a shared constituent, with no sequence of fusion operations assumed.

Under fusion, x is a DP whose lexical Head is D. Selected premodifiers and comparative complements belong within that DP; the independent partitive complement, compound restrictor, and ordinary postmodifiers belong to the Nom structure outside it, as in Figure 5. The permissions for the complete independent NP still exclude articles; for *every*, the fragment represents only the ordinary dependent pattern. Possessing a dependent Det use doesn't itself license an independent fused use.

Ordinary headedness uses the determinative's NP directly for bare, partitive, and externally determined expressions. In the fusion account, its DP occupies the further Nom structure just specified.

9.3 Degree uses outside noun phrases

When *enough* modifies *good* in *good enough*, the ordinary-Head analysis treats it as an NP modifier of an adjective. This would be a cost if NPs couldn't occur in that function, or if their distribution differed systematically from that of degree determinatives. The comparison therefore includes the degree uses of established NPs.

Enough tests both position and external function. It precedes a nominal in *enough money* and can follow one in *money enough*; post-head *enough* can't itself be premodified, as shown by **money almost enough* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 396–397, 445).

NP modification inside an AdjP also permits post-head position. In (3), I analyse *every Tuesday*, *this week*, and *next week* as temporal NP modifiers within the bracketed AdjPs. The separate degree modifiers and temporal specifications in the coordinated example make that attachment clear. These NPs express time, while *enough* expresses degree; the shared position leaves their selectional differences intact.

(3) a. *Applicants* [*completely free every Tuesday*] *will be interviewed next month.*
b. *Anyone* [*very busy this week*] *but* [*completely free next week*] *should contact me today.*

Enough also modifies adjectives, adverbs, verbs, and some PPs: *good enough*, *quickly enough*, *I hadn't prepared enough*, and *enough in control* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 396–397). The degree determinatives *much* and *little*, and *no*/*none*, likewise have uses outside NP structure (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 390, 395–397). Reynolds (2024) surveys the determinatives that modify AdjPs, AdvPs, and PPs (*more*, *less*, *enough*, *that*, *much*, *a little*, *all*) and finds their distribution idiosyncratic lexeme by lexeme, as adjective intensifiers are generally, with no pattern that sets *more* or *less* apart as an adverb; the modifying phrases take modifiers of their own (*far fewer*, *much more*, *so much*), the internal structure an NP headed by a determinative supplies.[12] *CGEL* lists ten determinatives that modify adjectives, among them *the* (*The bigger it is*) and *all* (*He seemed all confused*), and it notes that degree *all* occurs "as in NP structure, before *the* and *that*", as in *I feel all the better for it* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 549): the predeterminer order of *all the money*, inside an AdjP.[13]

NPs modify adjectives in *three years old*, *a great deal smaller*, and *plenty big enough*. *CGEL* also treats *lots better* and *heaps worse* as containing quantificational NP modifiers (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 549–550).

Attributive uses are the crucial test, because *CGEL* restricts NP modifiers there. *CGEL* contrasts predicative *a great deal better* with **some a great deal better proposals*, against permitted *some much better proposals* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 551–552). The excluded example also juxtaposes *some* and *a*; it doesn't isolate NP category as the cause. *CGEL* permits *She's a lot better player than me*, analysing the inner article as lost after the outer one (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 552, n. 8).

Informal attributive examples with nominal *heaps* and *lots* further qualify a categorical exclusion.[14] They don't establish the same distribution as degree determinatives. If degree determinatives

[12] *Both*, *either*, and *neither* also serve as markers of coordination (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1305, 1308). Their noun categorization would preserve that further category–function combination; this fragment doesn't analyse coordination.

[13] COCA, 15 October 2026: `[be] all the better`, 90 tokens.

[14] *Some heaps better photo's*: AULRO, moose, 19 August 2008, post 2; original spelling retained. *Some lots better ones*: Uber Drivers Forum, verified in an indexed excerpt; author and date remain unverified. These are informal attestations; any register restriction remains to be established.

systematically permit attributive uses excluded for established NP modifiers, that would favour DP projection.

9.4 Comparison of the two analyses

The articles' restrictions, *no*/*none* form selection, the compound restrictor conditions, and the differences among the noun subcategories in determination and modification are the same under both analyses.

The ordinary-Head account distinguishes NP-peripheral modifiers from the internal degree and cardinal approximative conditions (§5). For compounds, this NP–Nom boundary preserves the modifier-domain contrast that fusion expresses through its inner phrase and outer Nom (§6).

In the ordinary-Head account, *few* heads Nom and Nom heads NP across bare, partitive, and externally determined uses. In the fusion account, where one constituent fills Head and a dependent function together, its DP fills Det–Head in bare and partitive uses and Mod–Head with an external determiner (Table 2). In these matched examples, both have Nom as the NP's immediate Head. The contrast concerns the full Head chain and the additional fused functions.

I favour sharing the direct Head chain across determinative uses and with established nouns. The selection and attachment conditions preserve the modifier-domain contrast. Fusion instead shares a construction with adjectives. Both cover the matched cases with the same lexical restrictions; the trade-off concerns which structures the grammar shares. The wider profile comparison supplies the reason for preferring the grouping with nouns.

If determinative-headed and genitive expressions require different structural constraints after their independently motivated restrictions are held fixed, the shared-projection proposal in §9.2 loses its advantage. That would favour separate phrase types.

10 Ellipsis

A third analysis keeps a noun in independent uses but leaves it unpronounced: *take some [∅]*, *the lucky few [∅]*, *the some [∅] who say it*. The determinative is then an ordinary dependent, and the NP has an ordinary noun head that happens to be silent.

CGEL rejects ellipsis as a general account (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 420–421). In partitives there's no head to restore: **many ones of us*, **much quantity of it*. Generic *the rich* changes its meaning if *people* is added. And the NP construction lacks the marks of gapping. It isn't restricted to coordination, as in *Alice's performance of the Schubert took place immediately after Helen's of the Rachmaninov*, and it can't omit a sequence that isn't a constituent: **Alice's attempt to play the Schubert and Helen's the Rachmaninov*.

Payne et al. (2007, 570 n. 5) add an argument from adjacency. With a null head, nothing in the structure stops a dependent from intervening between the head and the overt material, so a null-headed analysis needs a stipulation to exclude **(this) once last* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 589), and another to exclude pre-head adjectives with the compounds (Payne et al., 2007, p. 584). The argument tells against ellipsis, not against ordinary Head, which has no null head either.

The some who bears on ellipsis directly. An elliptical *the some [∅] who say it* needs a source in which *the* and *some* precede a noun, and that's the sequence the corpus doesn't supply: of the 50 iWeb lines displayed for `the some people`, none has the reading of *the some who* (§3.3). Ellipsis would license, silently, a sequence that's excluded overtly. That's the problem *CGEL* raises for partitives, in a new place.

Ellipsis also needs a recoverable noun, and independent determinatives often have none. In *few would dare underestimate Aaron Finch's men*, nothing in view supplies the set, and that holds for 82 of 94 NOW lines for *few would* (§3.2). An ellipsis analysis can posit silent general nouns for such cases, but their content then comes from no antecedent. Ordinary Head lets the determinative's own meaning fix the interpretation, as a pronoun's does in *She left*.

What ellipsis shares with fusion is a list of licensers: the determinatives that allow a silent noun are the ones that allow independent use. It is the same list ordinary Head states as use permissions. Ellipsis adds a silent noun to it, and fusion adds a constituent with two mothers; ordinary Head adds neither.

11 Conclusion

Independent determinatives don't need fused functions. With *CGEL*'s categories unchanged, an ordinary-Head analysis gives bare, partitive, and externally determined uses a single chain: the determinative heads a nominal, and the nominal heads the noun phrase. That groups *the lucky few* with *the lucky survivors*, not with *the idle rich*, and it treats independent *few* alike with and without *the*. It also needs fewer constituents with two parents: fusion's shared node stays where adjectives need it, not where determinatives do.

The case that separates the analyses is *the some who*. Since *the* fills Det, a fused analysis has to make *some* a modifier-head, and for a determinative *CGEL* ties that to a use as internal modifier, which *some* lacks. So fusion has two options: list *the some* as an exception, as *CGEL* already does for *the both of us* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 377), or give up the condition. Payne et al. (2007, p. 570) allow fusion without a counterpart, but their one such case is the fused relative headed by a PP, AdjP, or AdvP (Payne et al., 2007, p. 575); every determinative they analyse has one, as *this once* has *this one time* (Payne et al., 2007, p. 588). Extending the exemption to determinatives would reduce the licence to a list of which determinatives take *the*, the permissions ordinary Head already states, and leave the shared node predicting nothing. A conversion analysis has a problem of its own. The one attested conversion of *some*, a writer's *nones and somes* for the religiously unaffiliated and affiliated, behaves as a converted noun does: it takes plural inflection and adjectives (*Catholic or Protestant somes*) and names a group by a property. *The some who* keeps the quantity reading of independent *some* instead. That doesn't exclude every conversion, since nouns such as *lot* quantify too, but the converted noun would have to keep exactly the properties of independent *some*. Under ordinary Head no fused-head licence is needed, only the lexical permissions every determinative has, and the rarity of *the some* has a plausible semantic source: existential *some* adds little once *the* has identified the set.

The same structure retires the complex determinatives. In *a few*, *a little*, and *a great many*, a peripheral *a* modifies an NP headed by *few*, *little*, or *many*. *Many a* has predeterminer *many* before an *a*-NP, like *such a* and *what a*. The decomposition rests on *CGEL*'s own record: *a few* admits *very*, *good*, and *fair*, and agreement follows the parts, plural after *a few* and singular after *many a man*. Their restrictions, including the polarity contrast between *few* and *a few*, become conditions on those modifiers.

Fusion remains for adjectives, where it has independent work, and for the nominal *nylon* and *double* constructions. The open question is phrase structure. If determinative-headed and genitive expressions turn out to need different constraints once their lexical restrictions are held fixed, separate phrase types would be favoured. Nothing here depends on whether determinatives are a kind of noun.

A grammar that keeps them a separate category adopts the analysis by licensing ordinary Head for both categories.

Data and analysis materials

The corpus lines cited here come from COCA, iWeb, and NOW (english-corpora.org). I gathered them by hand, and Claude Opus 5.5 classified them; each record gives the query, the date, the lines, and the reading assigned to each. The records, the quantifier and corpus supplements, and the search history are in the evidence repository, shared with a companion paper on the categorization of determinatives. A guide to the records each claim draws on accompanies this paper as `EVIDENCE.md`.

References

Abney, S. P. (1987). *The English noun phrase in its sentential aspect* [Doctoral dissertation, Massachusetts Institute of Technology].

Bruening, B. (2020). The head of the nominal is N, not D: N-to-D movement, hybrid agreement, and conventionalized expressions. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics*, *5*(1), Article 15. https://doi.org/10.5334/gjgl.1031

Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2002). *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316423530

Huddleston, R., Pullum, G. K., & Reynolds, B. (2022). *A student's introduction to English grammar* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009085748

Hudson, R. (2004). Are determiners heads? *Functions of Language*, *11*(1), 7–42. https://doi.org/10.1075/fol.11.1.03hud

Payne, J., Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2007). Fusion of functions: The syntax of *once*, *twice* and *thrice*. *Journal of Linguistics*, *43*(3), 565–603. https://doi.org/10.1017/S002222670700477X

Payne, J., Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2010). The distribution and category status of adjectives and adverbs. *Word Structure*, *3*(1), 31–81. https://doi.org/10.3366/E1750124510000486

Pullum, G. K. (2020). Theorizing about the syntax of human language: A radical alternative to generative formalisms. *Cadernos de Linguística*, *1*(1), 01–33. https://doi.org/10.25189/2675-4916.2020.v1.n1.id279

Pullum, G. K., & Miller, P. (2022). NPs versus DPs: Why Chomsky was right [Working paper. English version of Miller & Pullum 2022, *Revue CORELA* HS-37]. https://lingbuzz.net/lingbuzz/006845

Reynolds, B. (2024). Why *more* and *less* are never adverbs [First View; published online 4 October 2024]. *Journal of Linguistics*, 1–29. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0022226724000239

Reynolds, B. (2026). The lexicon–syntax boundary in English numerals: Cardinals, ordinals, and fractionals [Published online 4 February 2026]. *English Language and Linguistics*, 1–19. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1360674325100518

Van Eynde, F. (2007). The big mess construction. In S. Müller (Ed.), *Proceedings of the 14th international conference on Head-Driven Phrase Structure Grammar* (pp. 415–433). CSLI Publications. https://doi.org/10.21248/hpsg.2007.24

Van Langendonck, W. (1994). Determiners as heads? *Cognitive Linguistics*, *5*(3), 243–260. https://doi.org/10.1515/cogl.1994.5.3.243